The You of Tomorrow

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The You of Tomorrow

by lovevacation

Summary

Mydei, at sixteen, claims he will be single for life. Hephaestion totally believes him. 100%.

Notes

a real 'i wrote this instead of sleeping' work. please enjoy a group of bros doing their best.

See the end of the work for more notes

Mydeimos' bag slams against the cafeteria table with such force that Hephaestion winces for the poor books inside.

Leonnius, in the middle of drinking, chokes and fails to keep it all in his mouth. “Dude, my fucking choccy.”

“Will you *stop* calling it that. Hephaestion, your sanitizer,” Ptolemy immediately demands, stomping right past Mydeimos and taking the seat on Hephaestion’s other side.

“I thought you hated my sanitizer,” Hephaestion tells him. He starts digging though his jacket pockets anyway.

“Because you always buy that cheap gas station shit! Would it not kill you to invest in a floral scent at the least?” Despite his complaints, Ptolemy snatches Hephaestion’s little travel sanitizer the moment it appears and twists the cap off to upend the whole thing into his palms. “Even my own grandmother has better taste than you.”

“If you wanted to steal better-smelling hand sanitizer, why didn’t you ask Mydeimos?” Hephaestion asks.

“Because I don’t like him!”

On Hephaestion’s other side, Mydeimos is unbothered by this declaration. It is not the first time Ptolemy has claimed this, nor will it be the last. When Hephaestion turns, Mydeimos, too, is too busy cleaning his hands with his much fancier pomegranate sanitizer.

“What’s wrong with you two?” Perdikkas asks, finally concerned enough to look up from his homework.

“A couple of morons were trying to make a baby in the locker room,” Mydeimos grumbles.

Hephaestion fumbles with the empty bottle Ptolemy throws back at him. “In the middle of the day!?”

Leonnius groans. “Man, this again? I feel like it’s too early in our lives to be contemplating the ethics of exhibitionism."

“I think those are the biggest words I’ve heard you say all month,” Peucesta says from the other end of the table. He, too, is now interested enough to be distracted from his 3DS.

“Can we focus!? It’s not just about the ethics, it’s about the biohazards! Who knows what those fuckwits contaminated?”

Ptolemy is being his usual short-tempered self, but Hephaestion can see the way he can’t stop rubbing at his skin. He grabs a couple of his cafeteria napkins and wets them with his water bottle, grabbing his friend’s hands before he scratches himself bloody again. Ptolemy makes a strange squeaking noise as he does this.

“Four times,” Mydeimos mumbles as Hephaestion massages moisture into Ptolemy’s hands.

Hephaestion blinks. Mydeimos sounds… oddly tense. “What?”

“This is the fourth time I’ve walked into people having sex in this school,” his best friend continues. Their whole friend group stills at the way his expression darkens. “How does this keep fucking happening?”

“Four?” Leonnius suddenly straightens in his seat. “Wait, were *you* the one who caught those girls in the art room?”

Mydeimos scowls. “Yes.”

Peucesta turns. “And those teachers in the—”

“Yes.”

Perdikkas continues, “And that guy with the tuba in the—”

BANG. Mydeimos slams his fists into the table, causing everything on it to jump.

“*Yes.* Those were all me. Hephaestion, am I ill? Is there some sort of plague that rots the minds of teenagers the minute they hit sixteen that makes them unable to control their urges in public spaces?”

“And people say you aren’t dramatic,” Hephaestion mutters.

“No, he’s right.”

To his shock, it’s Perdikkas who says this. He looks completely serious as he does, too.

“There is an illness, Mydeimos,” continues their older friend. Slowly, he brings his hands together, and then curls them into a heart shape. “It’s called love.”

Mydeimos throws one of Hephaestion’s baby carrots at Perdikkas’ head.

“Ey, I know what he's talking about.” Leonnius, who has never been afraid of anything, not even Mydeimos’ wrath, leans over and swats his friend’s hand down before he can aim another projectile. “It’s shocking that a big-hearted guy like you doesn't understand, but you know, I get it. You’ve never felt that ‘spark’,” he says with his hands wiggling out like fireworks.

“What,” Mydeimos says.

Perdikkas jumps back in, clutching his heart. “The 'spark', Mydeimos! When you look at someone, and your breath is simply stolen away! Their lips glisten, their cheeks red, your hands shake as they try and fail to hold back from caressing that tender face…!”

“What the fuck are you reading,” Ptolemy says with disgust. Hephaestion is still massaging his hands.

“Is this still relevant to the tuba…?” Peucesta asks.

“Forget about the tuba,” Perdikkas hisses. He sighs, delicate as a maiden. “You guys will get it when you’re older. That all-consuming feeling you get when you’re with the one who sets your heart on fire. As if you two are the only ones left in the world…”

“I literally do not care,” says Mydeimos in a rare moment of raw disdain. For is patient, understanding best friend to have reached his limit like this, Hephaestion knows it’s serious. “There are six-hundred teenagers in this one building, and we all have to tolerate each other every nine months for four years. I have the right to be *irritated* if half of these people are too busy swapping spit to even notice that some of us are trying to get into the Grove!”

“Also, Perdikkas, you’re only a year older than us,” Hephaestion feels as though is important to add.

“Well excuse me for trying to make a case for people who still believe in romance!” the senior snaps.

“Okay, I take it back. Even I think whatever you just said is a real stretch to use that as an excuse for fucking in a high school,” Leonnius tells him. He downs what remains of his chocolate milk. “And besides, sparks just ain't for us, am I right? We’re all gonna be bachelors until we’re thirty. Bros for life!”

“What?” Hephaestion blurts. He’s never heard of this pact.

“I’m going to snap your head off of your shoulders,” Ptolemy tells Leonnius lowly. Perdikkas shakes his head with a disappointed scowl. Peucesta has returned to being consumed by his 3DS.

Leonnius gives them a thumbs up. “I’ll take that as a yes.”

“Whatever,” Mydeimos finally interjects, exhausted. “It’s not like I ever plan to get married, let alone meet anyone.”

“This again,” Hephaestion sighs.

“I mean it every time.”

“And I doubt it every time.” Hephaestion kicks Mydeimos in the leg, and his friend kicks him back. “I’ve known you since we were five, man. Call me back in ten years and tell me how little you care for the family life then.”

“I’ll be twenty-six. Pretty sure I’ll be too busy to think about anything but work,” Mydeimos says, finally taking out his lunch, which has been smooshed.

“Your plan for your mid-twenties is to be too busy to have a social life?” Hephaestion says, aghast. Even Peucesta seems disgusted by this.

“I didn’t say I wouldn’t have a social life. I just said I’d be prioritizing my work.”

This assurance only makes Perdikkas look more heartbroken. "...Guys, when's the last time we've taken Mydeimos out to the movies or something? He's being deprived of environmental stimulation. We need to do something before he stops feeling emotions altogether and perishes."

"Like a rabbit," Peucesta recognizes.

"Stop treating me like I'm dying!" Mydeimos says.

Leonnius makes a terrible soothing motion. "C'mon, man. We'll drop by that breakfast place you like this weekend! Deimos wants the pancakes? Deimos wants the strawberry pancakes?"

"Do *not* throw that!" Hephaestion snaps before Mydeimos can launch an entire protein shake at Leonnius' face.

"Phae, are you ever gonna let go of Ptolemy's hands? They look red," says Peucesta after a short scuffle.

"Shit." Hephaestion lets go of Ptolemy and tosses the wrung-out napkins side. Ptolemy blinks, brows drawn in irritation. "Sorry, my hands have a mind of their own when I'm distracted. I think Mydeimos has some lotion in his—"

"Don't bother," Ptolemy growls, and shoves his hands into his pockets. His ears are red. This entire conversation must have been way too overstimulating for him.

"Guys, can we fucking eat?" Hephaestion shouts at his friends. With a chorus of grumbles, everyone returns to their seats. As Mydeimos unpacks his fancy chicken salad, Hephaestion leans over to him. "Ten on Saturday?"

Mydeimos huffs. "Nine. Ten's too crowded."

"Nine on Saturday," Hephaestion tells the rest, who nod and sign 'ok' in response.

Internally, he sighs in relief.

As much as Hephaestion doesn't like the idea of Mydeimos being a bachelor for the rest of his life, he knows it's possible. If Mydeimos is anything, it's dutiful, and when he's responsible for something, he takes care of it. As his parents' only child, it's been a given since his birth that he'd inherit his father's company, so much that any other option has never even crossed his friend's mind. He may, truly, just devote his entire existence to it.

It's a fate that Hephaestion both curses and envies. He, himself, will most likely get a sports scholarship… somewhere. Perdikkas is already leaving to start pre-med next year, and who knows what may happen if Peucesta graduates from SoundCloud into a proper music career. Ptolemy will find some way to make money out of his literary fixation, whether as a critic or historian or professor. All Leonnius says is that he wants his motorcycle license the second he's old enough for it, and then he'll probably travel Amphoerus with it.

Honestly, the whole ‘relationships’ talk only has Hephaestion more worried about how much they’ll drift apart over the years. It scares him. He needs these guys. But speaking against it makes it feel like he's holding them back.

Mydeimos deserves that. He deserves someone who can see beyond his stubborn exterior and find the softie within that loves sweets and animals. Tall, handsome, and strong, yet devoted till the end. He really is the entire package, if those romantic dramas are anything to go by.

But dramas aren’t real life, and Hephaestion doesn't think Mydeimos deserves to survive twenty-six episodes of near-death experiences and misunderstandings for a chance at love.

Or does he? Depends on how desperate the situations gets.

Either way, Hephaestion is sure that whoever can make this guy see that dating is more than just a distraction and a biohazard will have his eternal gratitude.

“Mydeimos.”

A bus passes. Students flock from class to class. Some look over. Most don’t. This is not an unfamiliar sight.

“Mydeimos,” Hephaestion calls again. He barely even tries. He’s just saying it at this point.

“I never thought someone was even capable of bending like that,” says Peucesta from next to him in that bland tone of his.

“Mydeimos,” Hephaestion says again tiredly.

Shockingly, he finally gets a response. Mydeimos licks against his partner’s mouth one last time and presses a quick peck against his lips before shifting his eyes to his best friend. “What?”

“Oh, by Nikador, you answered,” Hephaestion says.

“What do you mean I answered?” Mydeimos asks, his hands absentmindedly pawing through his partner’s hair. Beneath him, Phainon is sprawled out in the grass, completely disconnected from reality. He presses kisses into Mydei’s neck and jaw with a lovesick dedication that Hephaestion has only seen on needy puppies.

“You were so busy trying to suck Phainon’s soul out of his body that I’m pretty sure you forgot that we're supposed to meet the guys for lunch in like… two minutes.” Hephaestion makes a show of checking his watch to prove his point. “Now are you going to ditch us or bring him along? Because I’m pretty sure it’s going to physically harm someone to separate you two right now.”

Mydeimos needs a moment for his brain to reboot. His hands drift down to Phainon's waist as he does this, feeling up Phainon like some squishable think toy that helps him concentrate. Does he even remember where they are? It's the middle of the Grove of Epiphany's campus square. Mydeimos is making out with his boyfriend in the middle of the the most populated area of one of the most prestigious colleges in Amphoreus.

Evidently, a lot can change in six years.

The catalyst of it all wiggles beneath Mydeimos, still looking dazed, but a bit more conscious of his surroundings than before. He sits up, forcing Mydeimos to do the same, and looks at his partner with those big blue eyes of his.

"Text me?" Phainon pleads, as though he needs to.

Mydeimos sighs, his hand dragging over Phainon's spine. *He needs pets and constant attention*, Hephaestion's brain supplies. "You're free, aren't you? Just come with us."

"I don't want to intrude…"

"You're with me. You're not intruding," says Mydeimos. *We are the same entity. Do not separate.*

Phainon turns to Hephaestion and Peucesta, and Hephaestion is not immune. It's not like he even needs convincing; he's the one who said Phainon could come. But Phainon is so courteous and understanding that he can't help but assure the guy anyways.

"Yeah, it's fine," he tells Mydeimos' boyfriend. "They'll be asking for you if you don't come, Phainon. You're part of the family." Next to him, Peucesta nods in agreement.

It does the trick. With one stupid couple now in tow, Hephaestion leads the way for the diner down the road where their friends wait.

Things may have changed, but it's not like Hephaestion hasn't learned to change with them. His sports scholarship flopped after his diagnosis, so now he's a civilian worker for the military. Peucesta goes to Paperfold U now and produces music with a ninja-weeb girl he met at the skate park. Leonnius's motorcycle sits cold most days ever since he started dating the twin sister of one of Mydeimos' friends, and he currently works in the mail service so he can afford a more accessible apartment. Perdikkas… Actually, Perdikkas is still working on getting into medical school. He's the only one who's had a predictable career so far.

Mydeimos, however, certainly takes the cake when it comes to wild turnarounds. He still a business major, but now aims to open a café instead of taking over Kremnos Tech. His parents were disappointed, but also surprisingly relived. Ever since giving up the company, Mydeimos has been discovering little parts of himself that he's been suppressing since childhood: his love of traveling, his fixation with dinosaurs, his eye for makeup and jewelry. He even has a mildly-successful cooking vlog.

And then, of course, there's Phainon.

“Hell yeah, it’s Phai! Pay up.”

Leonnius reaches out for what seems to be a won bet, but Ptolemy smacks his hand away. Perdikkas waves, looking every bit as the exhausted prospective med student he is, but still manages to be happy to see them. Phainon waves back with a big grin, his other hand latched to Mydeimos’, who responds to their enthusiasm with a grunt.

Their booth for six about to overflow, Ptolemy kicks Leonnius out of his side so he can grab Hephaestion and crowd him against the wall. Leonnius grumbles as he returns to his seat, and Phainon grabs a free chair from one of the tables to sit at the end. Peucesta then steals it for himself so that Phainon and Mydeimos can sit together.

Leonnius glances at the scene around him and sighs. “Man, I miss Lyxie. I should just leave.”

“No one is stopping you,” Ptolemy grumbles.

“How's that brew I recommended working out for you, Phainon? Sleeping better?” Perdikkas asks, ignoring them.

“Yeah, actually! Mydei says I've stopped moving around at night, though,” Phainon tells him.

“Isn’t that a good thing?” Hephaestion asks.

“It's weird,” Mydeimos mumbles as he flips through the menu. Ordering food for the both of them, it seems.

“He misses me being clingy,” Phainon translates with a grin. Mydeimos narrows his eyes but does not disagree with this, something Phainon rewards by leaning their heads together like a couple of joint puzzle pieces. “Don't worry, he likes it better that I'm sleeping. I'll miss when he would make me tea and watch documentaries with me in the middle of the night, but it's for the best.”

Hephaestion smiles. It's nice to hear Phainon talk like this. The guy's had a rough life, and had been constantly terrified at the beginning of their relationship that Mydeimos would get tired of him and leave. As the one who'd watched Mydeimos go from yearning rival to enamored boyfriend to devoted not-husband over the past four years, Hephaestion knew this to be highly unlikely, but it's been something Phainon’s had to figure out himself.

If only he could see the stark difference between the Mydeimos of today and pre-Phainon Mydeimos

It had been like any other day, back when Mydeimos had first started at the Grove. He'd told Hephaestion about a guy in his class who seemed to be competing with him for top scores. He'd called it childish. He then proceeded to talk about this guy and every stupid competition they got into for the next several months in ways that would leave Hephaestion staring at his phone wondering if he was being scammed.

Hephaestion remembers meeting Phainon for the first time along with Mydeimos' other college friends. He and Mydeimos seemed to be in constant orbit, always finding excuses to

take jabs at one another and monopolize each other's attention like a couple of kids pulling on each other's pigtails. Hephaestion doesn't think he could get either of them to go two seconds without bringing the other up, something that would have annoyed the hell out of Mydeimos had he been the one who had to listen to it.

It still astounds Hephaestion how besotted his best friend has become, but, then again, Phainon feels like the exact kind of person Mnestia would throw at Mydeimos just to prove a point. Phainon is driven and kind, with a passion for helping others while also being headstrong enough to meet Mydeimos in the middle. Him being handsome, smart, and built like a soldier at the same time just felt targeted. He and Mydeimos once got into a physical fight that left Mydeimos looking as though he'd realized he knew who he was going to spend the rest of his life with.

Taking in the couple at first glance, it's easy to mistake Phainon as the one who likes Mydeimos more; he certainly makes an effort for it. But while Phainon seems to be the one with an addiction to kissing Mydeimos, Mydeimos is like a cat: if he didn't want it, he'd leave. And Mydeimos very, very much encourages this behavior and relishes in it with barely-concealed satisfaction. If Phainon isn't hanging off of Mydeimos for some reason, Mydeimos is touching Phainon in some way: a hand on the small of his back, their arms joint, their thighs pressed against each other. Hephaestion has even had to tolerate several evenings at people's houses that just involved Mydeimos wrapped around Phainon's middle and occasionally gnawing at his boyfriend's neck like a shameless mating animal. Phainon, of course, loves this and does nothing to stop it.

Not to mention, it had been Mydeimos' idea to move in together before they'd even finished college. Mydeimos, who had stared at every jewelry store window before he custom ordered a pair of rings to hide in his seasoning cabinet. Mydeimos, who has recently been looking at land for them to live on once they have the money for it. Mydeimos, who got Phainon a *dog* before they even started dating because Phainon was *homesick*.

Hephaestion wonders what would happen if he could go back in time and shove a picture of Phainon's handsome face at a teenage Mydeimos. *Look at him. Look how fucked you are.*

As if reading Hephaestion's mind, as he usually does, Ptolemy snorts at the couple opposite to them. "From self-proclaimed eternal bachelor to clingy baby. What's next? Already have your kids' names picked out? Let me guess: two girls and one boy."

"I don't care about genders," Mydeimos claims.

"Why can't we have two girls and two boys?" Phainon genuinely asks.

Ptolemy sighs, pressing on his temple. "I'm losing my touch."

Hephaestion reaches over and rubs his thigh in a comforting motion. "You should know how much love changes a man."

It is sweet, the way Ptolemy only ever seems to be rendered speechless whenever Hephaestion says stuff like this. This is the man who followed him back to Kremnos after

Hephaestion had to drop out of college. He's a local librarian now. It's forced him to mellow out, and it's kinda hot how good he’s gotten with kids.

Hephaestion wonders if this is how Phainon feels when he's with Mydeimos, turning a man so guarded into a walking ball of affection with his existence alone.

He looks back to the couple. Phainon is talking to Leonnius excitably about something that happened at the gym, his arm wrapped around Mydeimos’ waist and his gaze shifting back to his boyfriend every once in a while just to watch him speak or squint or do nothing at all. It's less like he's multitasking and more like appreciating Mydeimos’ existence is his default setting, one he's always happy to return to.

Life is as brutal as it is strange, most of the time. It gives and it takes, and you never know where you'll end up until you get there.

But sometimes, Hephaestion thinks, the things you wish for do come true.

Heh, they must have done something good in their last lives to have earned this.

End Notes

have been needing to write the detachment five watching mydei fail spectacularly at not becoming a simp for his fluffy boyf. cheers if you're also reading embers of a star! i love writing them.

man, i feel real old for giving peucesta a 3ds... goat handheld

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